

## Episode 146: Long Ago... 85 1995 Part 5 Shocking March (Final) What Awaited Us in Tokyo...

For several years now, I've been using a razor-type shaver to shave my beard. Until then, I used an electric shaver, but that thing surprisingly scatters the shaved whiskers. Well, maybe the more expensive models don't do this, but anyway, the several-thousand-yen class one I was using splendidly scattered shaved whiskers everywhere. Once I noticed this one day, it bothered me so much that I ultimately converted to using a razor-type shaver.

When shaving with that razor-type shaver, I use something called shaving cream. Lotions, gels - various types have come out recently, but I'm definitely a shaving cream devotee. However, the thing is, I don't know the proper amount.

How much should I smear on my face each time before starting to shave? I've been unable to find the answer to this day. Shaving cream has that nice fluffy texture that makes you want to use lots and put it on your face, but does that actually help with the original act of shaving whiskers? If you put too much on, maybe you can't actually shave whiskers properly? But if it's too little, that's lonely in its own way.

Every time I shave, I think about such things and try various approaches. But I still tend to use too much cream. It's also fun to see myself like that at 47.

Anyway.

After being "kidnapped" at Seoul's Gimpo Airport, we were split between two cars and first taken to D Company's headquarters.

Where exactly we drove - well, it was my first time in Seoul. No matter where we went, I had no idea (laugh), but the company was in what seemed like a somewhat downtown-ish(?) area. We were shown to the chairman's office. There was the chairman who was the mastermind behind our "kidnapping."

"'Thank you for this time' - it's strange for us to say that, isn't it?" I thought while giving greetings anyway. Come to think of it, I remembered gradually that I had met this person in Tokyo before. Then, one after another, familiar faces were invited into the room. Korean animators and art staff. They were all people who had come to work at Toei Animation (東映動画) for a period, so we knew each other loosely. We chatted for a while. Oh yes, everyone spoke Japanese fluently. This always amazes me. We can only say things like "Kamsahamnida" or "Maekchu juseyo" or "Jeongmal masisseoyo!" - quite mysterious and somewhat frustrating moments.

Lunch with other company employees at a restaurant near headquarters. After eating and returning, the chairman asked, "So, where would you like to go?" "We'd like to see production company studios here," we said. Somehow, we were really serious about these kinds of things. Or rather, Seoul animation production sites were definitely spots we couldn't easily see otherwise. What we most wanted to see in Seoul was actually animation studios (laugh).

"Well, Kim-san will come soon, so it would be good to see Kim-san's company." At that time, D Company was already shifting from animation production to rights management and publishing business, and the production site had become quite small. Kim-san, who arrived shortly after, was president of E Company, a production company that had participated as a main force during the crunch for the recent theatrical *Dragon Ball Z*. So we could actually observe a hot, current production site.

"Well, welcome!" said Kim-san. Come to think of it, I had met her in Tokyo a month earlier. Felt a bit strange (laugh). Leaving D Company, we headed to E Company. Again, I didn't really know the location, but apparently several production companies were gathered in this area. We were invited inside and immediately began touring. Staff had mostly gone home right after a busy project ended, but we were super lucky to see an actual working site.

What interested me was naturally the finishing (仕上げ) department. The studio's second floor was the finishing room, and wow, you could feel the fighting spirit! There were ingenious touches everywhere for efficiently progressing work in short time - very educational.

For example, paint bottles. Normally you line up paints in thin glass bottles, but honestly, there's limited space around desks so you can't line up very many. At this studio, they were amazingly using 35mm negative film - you know, regular camera film containers. They put paint in those cases! Of course, colours used in large quantities were in glass bottles, but for colours used only a little at a time but with quite a variety of colours, this method worked well. Since they're low height, you can line them up in desk drawers.

Come to think of it, domestically (within Toei Animation?) there were small glass bottles called "tracing bottles," and tracers did colour tracing with paint in those. Thinking about it, we also used paint in tracing bottles for minor corrections during inspection.

A further innovation was drying shelf usage. To dry paint applied to cels, you put painted cels one by one on shelves, but here they rolled them tightly and stuck them in shelves to save space. They'd roll them into horizontal U-shapes and push them into 3-4 centimetre gaps between upper and lower shelf boards. Since cels have resilient force trying to return to their original shape, being held down by upper and lower shelf boards prevents cels from sticking together. We often used such methods for long cels, but here they used this method even for standard cels. It's impossible for large painted areas, but for small painted areas or things painted only on the right or left half of cels, unpainted parts can be rolled and turned upside down safely. Moreover, since they were using high-viscosity Taiyo Shisai paint, such feats might be possible. Well, maybe I just didn't know and the same thing was being done at domestic finishing production companies using Taiyo colours, but in any case, for us using low-viscosity STAC paint, it was eye-opening to see methods we'd never thought of!

Other areas - animation and art - all seemed to have their own unique innovations, making for quite good learning!

Now. After the tour ended, it was already evening. That night, Kim-san took us to an extremely expensive-looking Korean court cuisine restaurant. A banquet hosted by D Company's chairman from earlier. We enjoyed delicious food here. And afterward, amazingly, a casino. Seoul has public casinos. Actually, the president of a certain K Production from Japan happened to be in D Company's chairman's office earlier, and he took us for a casino experience. Everyone except me was experiencing casinos for the first time. Actually, I had already experienced it in Manila. The result? Amazingly, only I made quite a profit! So I paid for the taxi fare back to the hotel and tips. The next day I bought a pretty nice bag with that money (laugh).

The next day was a full day of sightseeing. Again cared for by E Company's Kim-san. Touring around Seoul in her car. And that night, another banquet by D Company's chairman (laugh). It had become such an embarrassingly grand hospitality tour. Come to think of it, what happened to the package tour we were supposed to participate in? (bitter laugh)

And the day after that, we were already returning home. Reunited with the tour guide at the airport (bitter laugh). We had her handle procedures quietly without much conversation and became passengers.

On that flight, I encountered tremendously sad news. Voice actor Yamada Yasuo-san, famous for *Lupin III*, had passed away. I learnt this from Japanese newspapers on the plane. This was shocking. We spoke little, and the plane headed to Narita.

And at Narita Airport, we would encounter even more surprising news. That morning, someone had spread sarin gas in Tokyo's subway, resulting in many deaths! It had become a major confusion, a major incident! We were stunned. It was March 20, 1995.

(10,11,30)